

TOPIC 7: DEMOCRACY IN PRACTICE

1. Meaning of Democracy

Democracy is a system of government in which power belongs to the people. The people exercise power mainly by electing representatives and by participating in public life. Key ideas include free and fair elections, rule of law, majority rule with respect for minority rights, and accountability of leaders.

2. Elections

Elections are the process by which citizens choose their leaders. For elections to be democratic they should be free, fair, periodic and open to eligible voters. Independent electoral bodies, transparent counting and peaceful acceptance of results support credibility.

3. Political Parties

Political parties are organised groups that seek to win elections and form government. They present candidates, programmes and policies. Multi-party competition gives voters choice. Parties should operate within the law and avoid violence and hate speech.

4. Voting Process

Eligible citizens register, turn up at polling units with proper identification, receive ballots, vote in secret, and have their votes counted. Civic education helps voters understand issues and choose responsibly. After voting, citizens should respect the outcome and use legal channels to challenge irregularities.

5. Summary

Democracy in practice depends on free elections, responsible political parties and informed voting. Citizens keep democracy alive by participating peacefully and holding leaders accountable.

End of Topic 7